TOOL

What to Include in a Persona Description

A persona is a model of the user that is used in the HCD process. It is a fictional character that you compose based on the information you collected about the real people with whom you interacted during the contextual interviews. It is not one of the interviewees, and it is not made up based on your intuition or stereotypical assumptions about this user group. The description of a persona characterizes how users behave and think, as well as what they wish to accomplish and why.



Background: Who They Are

Demographics	Typically consists of name, age, occupation, and other details that are relevant to the focus of your design project. • Add a representative photo from a free repository (e.g., pixabay.com). • Choose a name for the persona (http://www.babynamewizard.com/voyager is a useful resource for finding age-appropriate names).
Skills	What they know and can do, related to the problem space.
Attitudes, beliefs, values	Things that the persona cares about in their life/work and that may affect their interactions related to the focus of your project.
Past experiences	Stories from the past that affect the persona's skills, attitudes, and goals.

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Goals: What Motivates Them

Life goals	What they want to achieve in the long term, with respect to the focus of the design problem. This contextualizes the bigger picture in which the persona is operating.
End goals	What they want to achieve in the short term. This includes the primary functionality that the persona needs and that is relevant to the topic of the design problem. Articulating this will serve as justification for the design of the product. What is it that the persona wants/needs to accomplish?
Experience goals	What they wish to experience and feel while they are working toward achieving their end goals. This responds to social and emotional aspects in the context in which they are achieving their end goals and later will serve to understand the emotional and social aspects of the experience designed into the product.



Behaviors: What They Do

Activities	List the activities that the persona completes toward achieving their goals at all three levels (life, end, and experience goals). These should be activities related to the focus of the design problem and should include typical cases as discovered in your user research, not the unique behaviors that stand out as edge cases.
Successes	Describe cases in which the persona was successful in completing their activities and achieving their goals. Add information that explains this success.
Frustrations	Describe cases in which the persona failed to complete their activities and achieve their goals. Add information that explains this failure and describe the frustrations, struggles, or challenges the persona is facing.

Note: If you do not have data from your contextual interviews to include in a specific element of the persona, leave it out: Do not make up details based on your intuition or stereotypical assumptions. Therefore, during the contextual interviews, make sure that you collect data that will allow you to compose a complete persona.

More information about constructing effective personas can be found here:
https://www.cooper.com/journal/2001/08/perfecting_your_personas

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